# The Empty Tomb

*Mark 16:1–8 · Luke 24 · John 20–21 · 1 Corinthians 15:3–8*

**The big idea:** On Sunday morning the tomb was empty. The risen Jesus met Mary by name, showed his hands to frightened disciples, met Thomas in his doubt, and restored Peter. Over forty days he appeared to many witnesses, more than five hundred at once.

## Before you meet: Read

Mark 16:1–8 | John 20:11–29 | John 21:15–17 | 1 Corinthians 15:3–8

## Open (5 minutes)

**Have you ever lost all hope about something and then had it turned around? What happened?**

## Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Why do you seek the living among the _____? He is not here, but has risen." *(Luke 24:5–6)*

"Do not disbelieve, but _____." *(John 20:27)*

"Blessed are those who have not _____ and yet have believed." *(John 20:29)*

## Discuss

**1. Why does it matter that women were the first witnesses to the empty tomb?** *Mark 16:1–8; John 20:11–18*

**2. Jesus ate fish and showed his scars. Why does it matter that his resurrection body was real and physical?** *Luke 24:36–43; John 20:27*

**3. Jesus restored Peter after his denial. What does that say to someone who has failed Jesus badly?** *John 21:15–17*

## Memory verse

> *"I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die."*
>
> **John 11:25–26**

## Pray

Praise the risen Lord. Bring him your fear, your doubt, or your failure, and thank him that he comes with peace and knows your name.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 43

# The Empty Tomb

## Session plan (about 45 minutes)

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| **5 min** | Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question. |
| **10 min** | Read John 20:11–29 aloud together. |
| **5 min** | Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below. |
| **20 min** | Discuss: choose three of the questions. |
| **5 min** | Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (1 Corinthians 15 and Acts 1:1–11). |

## Main points to land

1. The tomb was empty and the risen Jesus appeared to many witnesses over forty days, including more than five hundred at once (1 Corinthians 15:3–8; Acts 1:3).
2. His resurrection body was real and physical, scarred and yet never to die (Luke 24:39–43; John 20:27).
3. The risen Jesus came to fearful, doubting, and failed people, brought them peace, and sent them out (John 20:19–21; 21:15–17).

## Answer key (Observe)

1. dead
2. believe
3. seen

## Questions people will ask

**Couldn't the disciples have stolen the body or imagined seeing Jesus?**
Frightened men hiding behind locked doors became bold witnesses, and several were killed rather than deny what they had seen. Hundreds saw him, some at once and many still alive when Paul wrote (1 Corinthians 15:6). People do not die for a story they know they made up, and group visions of a man who eats fish do not happen.

## Closing prayer

Risen Lord Jesus, you came to Mary, to Thomas, and to Peter, and you come to us. Thank you that you are alive, that you bring peace, and that you restore people who have failed you. Make us glad witnesses of your resurrection. Amen.